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The Video Game Script Method

Many videos lose people because the viewer cannot tell where the video is going, even when the topic is good. This guide gives you a simple script template borrowed from video games: a clear quest, a few missions, short save points and one final payoff. It works for long-form videos of 8 to 20 minutes, including faceless narrated ones.

> How to use: Read the template once, copy the fill-in lines into a document, then use the prompts with ChatGPT, Claude or Gemini to draft each part. Write the script first and think about visuals afterwards.

Why a game works

When you publish, YouTube tends to show a new video to a small group of viewers first. After that, two things matter most: whether people click, and whether they keep watching. Your title and thumbnail decide the first. The script does most of the work on the second, which is why a clear script usually helps more than better visuals.

Games keep people playing because the player always knows the goal, meets something a little difficult, and gets a reward before the next step. A script built the same way gives the viewer a reason to stay at every point. Because it is a repeatable template, you never start from a blank page. You start with a quest and fill in the missions.

The template

1. **Title screen.** Name the quest and say why it is worth staying for, in plain words. Hint at the final boss without giving it away. About 20 to 30 seconds. Fill in: "By the end of this video you will [quest outcome], and the part most people miss is [final boss teaser]."
2. **Mission 1.** The first and easiest step. State the goal, raise a small obstacle or question, then solve it so the viewer gets an early win. About 2 to 2.5 minutes. Fill in: "First mission: [goal]. The catch is [obstacle or question]. Here is how to get past it: [payoff]."
3. **Save point.** A one-line recap and a reason to continue. About 10 to 15 seconds. Fill in: "So now you have [what was solved]. But that only works if [open question the next mission answers]."
4. **Mission 2.** This mission builds on the first, with a slightly harder obstacle. About 2 to 2.5 minutes. Fill in: "Mission two: [goal]. This is where [common mistake or problem] usually trips people up. The fix is [payoff]."
5. **Save point.** Another brief pause that points ahead. About 10 to 15 seconds. Fill in: "That is [recap in one line]. The next part is where [reason the next mission matters]."

6. **Mission 3.** The hardest mission, which sets up the final boss. About 2 to 2.5 minutes. Fill in: "Mission three: [goal]. The question here is [question], and the answer changes how you [related action]."
7. **Final boss.** The biggest payoff, the one the title screen promised. Deliver it plainly and stop soon after. About 1.5 to 2 minutes. Fill in: "Here is the part I promised at the start: [biggest payoff], because [reason it works]."
8. **Credits.** One or two sentences to close, with an optional pointer to a related video. Do not wrap up at length or recap everything. About 15 to 20 seconds. Fill in: "That is the quest complete. If you want [related next step], [next video or resource] picks up from here."

A worked example

Say your video is about repotting a houseplant that keeps dying. The quest is to help the viewer repot a struggling plant and keep it alive afterwards. The final boss is what to do in the first two weeks after repotting, which is where a lot of the good work gets undone.

1. **Title screen.** "By the end of this video you will know how to repot a plant that keeps dying, and what to do in the fortnight afterwards, which is the part most people get wrong."
2. **Mission 1.** Goal: find out what is wrong. Obstacle: yellow leaves can mean too much water or too little. Payoff: check the roots, because firm, pale roots and soft, dark roots tell two very different stories.
3. **Save point.** "Now you know what the roots are telling you. But the right fix depends on what you put them in next."
4. **Mission 2.** Goal: choose the pot and soil. Obstacle: a much bigger pot feels kinder. Payoff: go only a little larger, make sure there is a drainage hole, and use a mix that suits the plant.
5. **Save point.** "Pot and soil sorted. Next comes the move itself, which is where roots get damaged."
6. **Mission 3.** Goal: repot without harm. Question: how much of the old soil should come off? Payoff: loosen it gently, trim only the soft roots, and set the plant at the same depth as before.
7. **Final boss.** The first fortnight. Water once, then wait until the top few centimetres are dry before watering again, and keep the plant out of direct sun while it settles.
8. **Credits.** "That is the quest done. If the leaves still look tired in a month, the light guide picks up from here."

Prompts to fill it in

1. **Finding the quest.** "I make YouTube videos about [niche] for [audience]. My next topic is [topic]. Suggest five possible quests for this video, each written as one clear outcome the viewer will have by the end. For each one, name a final boss: the single most useful or surprising payoff the video could build towards. Keep the language plain."

2. **Splitting the topic into missions.** "My quest is [quest] and my final boss is [final boss]. Split the topic into three missions that lead towards it, from easiest to hardest. For each mission, give a goal, one small obstacle or question the viewer is likely to have, and the payoff that resolves it. The video will be about [length] minutes long."
3. **Writing the title-screen hook.** "Write three versions of a title-screen hook for a video with this quest: [quest]. Each should be under [number] words, say clearly what the viewer will get, and hint at [final boss] without revealing it. Avoid hype and clickbait phrasing. My tone is [tone]."
4. **Writing save points.** "Here are my three missions: [paste missions]. Write a save point to go between each pair. Each one needs one line recapping what was just solved and one line giving a reason to keep watching that ties to the next mission. Keep each save point under 30 words."
5. **Checking each mission pays off.** "Read these missions from my script: [paste missions]. For each one, tell me whether it has a clear goal, a real obstacle or question, and a payoff that resolves it. Where a payoff is missing, vague or arrives too late, say so and suggest a fix in one or two sentences."
6. **Retention read-through.** "Here is my full script: [paste script]. Read it as a first-time viewer who could leave at any moment. Mark every place where attention might drop, such as a slow opening, a repeated point, a missing reason to continue or a long wrap-up after the final boss. For each one, quote the line and suggest a tighter version."

Before you record

1. **The quest fits in one sentence.** You can say it aloud in one breath, and the title screen states it within the first 30 seconds.
2. **Every mission pays off.** Each mission ends with something solved, not just explained.
3. **Save points stay short.** They hold one line of recap and one reason to continue, and nothing more.
4. **The final boss keeps the promise.** The biggest payoff comes last, it matches what the title screen promised, and the video ends soon after.
5. **You have read it aloud.** Read the full script aloud once and cut any line you stumble over or would skip as a viewer.
6. **You have planned the edit.** The edit, for example in CapCut, is where the structure gets tightened. Note where you will trim pauses, remove repeated points and keep the save points brisk.

Want to go further

If this template is useful, The Hook & Retention Workshop picks up where it leaves off. It has 16 more prompts covering hooks, missions, re-hooks, the CapCut edit pass and reading the retention graph, so you can see where viewers stay and where they drift away. You can find it at carlssonandcolibrary.se.